

ARUN KUMAR

COAL; MINES

G. KISHAN REDDY, *64* | BJP
Minister of Coal; Mines

First-generation politician Born in an agricultural household, he was the undivided Andhra BJP's president before becoming the Telangana unit's chief, a post he occupied again in 2023

Second term Lok Sabha member from Secunderabad since 2019, he held several portfolios in Modi 2.0, including tourism and culture

Minister of State



SATISH CHANDRA DUBEY, *49* | BJP

Debut in Modi's council
A Rajya Sabha MP from Bihar, the saffron leader previously represented Valmiki Nagar constituency in the Lok Sabha (2014-19)

Public–Private Synergy Vital

The lifeline of many industries, coal sector reform must continue in earnest under the new minister

By SONAL KHETARPAL

Coal remains the most crucial fossil fuel for India, fulfilling over half of the country's energy needs. Despite ranking fifth in terms of coal reserves globally, domestic production—which stood at 777 million tonne in FY22—falls short of the growing demand. In fact, the sector faces significant challenges due to its reliance on labour-intensive methods and lack of technological advancements. Consequently, nearly 20 per cent of India's coal demand is met through imports at high costs, subjecting the industry to currency fluctuations and global supply chain disruptions.

As India progresses towards cleaner and renewable energy sources, there is a strong policy push to reduce its coal dependence. Moreover, the mining sector is increasingly focused on Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) criteria for sustainable mining of coal. However, coal companies often struggle to comply with these stringent requirements, making the ministry's role amid private participation even more crucial. ■

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

ENHANCE MINING PRODUCTIVITY
Doing so is essential for reducing the country's reliance on imports, for which digitisation and automation of operations must also be incorporated. The focus should be on increasing volume as well as competitiveness

PRIVATE PUSH A start was made in 2020. Opening up coal mining to private players further can lead to increased technological investments, boosting domestic productivity

CLEAR ROAD MAP
With rising environmental concerns, diversifying coal usage has become essential. India's National Coal Gasification Mission aims to achieve 100 MT of coal gasification by 2030, for which a detailed road map should be prioritised to encourage investments